

Countable and uncountable nouns

Teaching guide

Talk about amounts using the right noun pattern.

Understand the distinction

Countable nouns can have singular and plural forms: a chair, two chairs. Uncountable uses describe a mass or general idea: some furniture, some advice. Use a piece of advice or an item of furniture to count units.

Countability belongs to a use, not always to a word forever. Coffee can be a drink in general or a countable serving: two coffees. Use a dictionary to check unfamiliar meanings. Information, advice, and equipment are normally uncountable in general English.

Compare the patterns

COUNT

We need three chairs.

Individual chairs can be counted.

AMOUNT

We need some furniture.

Furniture is normally uncountable.

UNIT

She gave me two pieces of advice.

Pieces provides a countable unit.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose: a useful information / some useful information

A. two useful informations

B. some useful information

C. a useful information

2. Which phrase correctly counts two units of advice?

A. two pieces of advice

B. two advices

C. two advice

3. Can two coffees be natural in a cafe?

A. No. Coffee can never be used as a countable noun.

B. Yes. It always means two types of coffee beans.

C. Yes. It can mean two servings of coffee.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You need two chairs and an unspecified amount of storage furniture. Which sentence states this correctly?

- A. I need two chair and some furniture for storage.
- B. I need two chairs and two furnitures for storage.
- C. I need two chairs and some furniture for storage.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. some useful information

Information is normally uncountable.

A: For individual units, say two pieces of information.

C: Information is normally uncountable; use some information or a piece of information.

2. A. two pieces of advice

Use a unit expression rather than advices.

B: Advice is normally uncountable; count pieces of advice.

C: Use a unit phrase: two pieces of advice.

3. C. Yes. It can mean two servings of coffee.

A word can have a countable use in a particular context.

A: In a cafe, coffees can mean servings.

B: Two coffees can simply mean two drinks, not necessarily different types.

4. C. I need two chairs and some furniture for storage.

Chairs is countable; furniture is normally uncountable.

A: After two, use plural chairs.

B: Use pieces of furniture to count units of furniture.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-21.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

You need two chairs and an unspecified amount of storage furniture. Which sentence states this correctly?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.